Soumitra Shukla

soumitra.shukla@yale.edu soumitrashukla.github.io

Education

Yale University **Sep. 2015 – May 2021**
Ph.D. in Economics (with Distinction) *New Haven, CT*

Yale University **Sep. 2015 – Dec 2017**
M.Phil. in Economics (with Distinction) *New Haven, CT*

University of Minnesota **Sep. 2010 – May 2015**
B.S. in Economics and Mathematics (with Distinction) *Minneapolis, MN*

Doctoral Qualifying Exams

Labor Economics (with Distinction) and Industrial Organization

Fields of Concentration

- Organizational Economics, Labor Economics, and Personnel Economics

Employment

- Research Economist, Burning Glass Institute, (Incoming)
- Economist, Federal Reserve Board, 2021-2024

Other Affiliations

- Research Affiliate, Department of Economics, Yale University, 2021-present

Working Papers

- **Making the Elite: Class Discrimination at Top Firms**

  How salient is hiring discrimination in driving socioeconomic gaps in access to elite jobs, and where in the hiring process do these disparities arise? These questions are particularly challenging to answer regarding social status or class discrimination in elite hiring. Although such discrimination is widely acknowledged, identifying its source has proven elusive in Western contexts, where social position must be inferred from multiple markers such as accent, education, and networks. India's caste system provides a uniquely clear measure of social status, allowing more precise identification of where and how status shapes access to top jobs. Analyzing detailed screening data from US and European multinationals hiring in India, this paper provides the first systematic evidence quantifying both the salience and source of social status or class discrimination in elite hiring. Subjective personal interviews assessing "fit" are the primary mechanism for revealing and penalizing social position in elite job recruitment. Nearly 90 percent of caste disparities in hiring emerge during such fit assessments. The higher promotion rates of disadvantaged castes—about 20 percent even in the most selective jobs—suggest that any information gained during personal interviews cannot justify these hiring disparities. These findings reveal how subjective "fit"-focused assessments in elite hiring can systematically exclude high-potential talent based on social status. This presents a fundamental challenge for organizations worldwide: how can they retain necessary managerial discretion in hiring while preventing the kind of status-based discrimination that undermines both diversity and talent optimization?

- **Interviews**, with Jason Sockin and Elliott Ash

  Interviews allow employers to learn about workers, but do they also enable workers to learn about firms? Using data on hundreds of thousands of interview reports from Glassdoor, we find that candidates for high-paying jobs are 9 percent more likely to reject a job offer if they believe the interview was easy. Easy interviews appear to convey poor "fit" as those who accept offers after easy interviews are one half of a standard deviation less satisfied with their jobs and 14 percent less likely to remain with their employer at least one year. Analysis of interview narratives using a large language model reveals that difficult interviews signal colleague ability and opportunities for skill development, whereas easy interviews convey a nonselective process. Interviews offer workers a preview of match quality, highlighting a unique channel through which labor markets may become more inefficient if firms fully automate their hiring processes with AI.

- **Personality and Professional Pathways: Socioemotional Predictors of Success in an Elite MBA Program**, with John Eric Humphries

  This paper provides new evidence on how socioemotional skills shape key outcomes at an elite U.S. business school, with important implications for academic and career success. Socioemotional skills like compassion, gregariousness, and assertiveness are assessed using forced-choice methods that prevent "gaming." The paper examines how these skills influence academic performance, job search behavior, and job offer industry and compensation. The findings are threefold: First, socioemotional skills often outpredict the effects of standardized test scores. Second, the relative importance of different skills varies across academic and career outcomes. Third, these skills operate through distinct channels—for example, while both industriousness and gregariousness predict higher compensation, industriousness is more strongly linked to academic performance, while gregariousness drives job search intensity. These results offer new evidence on how personality influences specialization, job outcomes, and compensation, with important implications for talent management and career development.

Fellowships, Honors and Awards

- University Dissertation Fellowship, Yale University, 2020-2021
- University Fellowship, Yale University, 2015-2020
- Carl Arvid Anderson Prize Fellowship, Yale University, 2019–2020
- Cowles Foundation Fellowship, Yale University, 2015–2019
- Economic Growth Center Prize, Yale University, 2015-2020
- Raymond Powell Prize (for teaching), Yale University, 2018–2019
- Lester Page Hoole Fellow, Yale University, 2017-2018
- Distinction in the Labor Economics Oral Qualifying Exam, Yale University, 2017
- Ella Thorp Scholarship, University of Minnesota, 2014-2015
- Linda and Ted Johnson Research Fellowship, University of Minnesota, 2014-2015
- Phi Beta Kappa (top 2% of class), University of Minnesota, 2014
- Phi Kappa Phi (top 5% of class), University of Minnesota, 2014
- Talle Family Scholarship, University of Minnesota, 2013-2014
- Stockman Scholarship, University of Minnesota, 2012-13
- Undergraduate Research Opportunities Award, University of Minnesota, 2012
- Meritorious Winner: Mathematical Contest in Modeling, University of Minnesota, 2012
- University Honors Program, University of Minnesota, 2011

Research Grants

- Cowles Foundation Research Grant, 2017-2021

Invited Conferences and Talks

- 2025: MIT, Georgetown University, NBER Race and Stratification Conference
- 2024: System Equitable Growth Conference, Society for Institutional and Organizational Economics (University of Chicago), NBER Summer Institute (Personnel Economics), People and Organizations Conference (Wharton), NBER Economics of Mobility Conference, NBER Organizational Economics
- 2023: Discrimination in the 21st Century: Fostering Conversations Across Fields (Chicago Booth and the Becker-Friedman Institute for Economics), NBER Economics of Mobility Conference
- 2022: Discrimination and Disparities Seminar, Discrimination in the 21st Century: Fostering Conversations Across Fields (Chicago Booth and the Becker-Friedman Institute for Economics)
- 2021: Wharton (Business Economics and Public Policy), Penn State (Economics of Education Seminar)

Journal Refereeing & Grant Reviews

Quarterly Journal of Economics, Journal of Political Economy, Economics Letters, National Science Foundation, American Economic Journal: Applied Economics

References

Prof. Joseph G. Altonji
Yale University
Department of Economics
New Haven, CT 06520
Phone: +1 (203) 687 6077
✉ joseph.altonji@yale.edu

Prof. Costas Meghir
Yale University
Department of Economics
New Haven, CT 06520
Phone: +1 (646) 532 9154
✉ c.meghir@yale.edu

Prof. John Eric Humphries
Yale University
Department of Economics
New Haven, CT 06520
Phone: +1 (773) 633 8483
✉ johneric.humphries@yale.edu

Dr. Jasper Hoek
Deputy Associate Director
Federal Reserve Board
Washington, DC 20001
Phone: +1 (202) 714 0605
✉ jasper.hoek@frb.gov